STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 24 · Give Your Son a Day

Transcript · Wes Hart

Hey. Good to see you in a chair. Come on, settle in. Uh, some of you fought the drive to get here. You came anyway. I'm glad. Last lesson we stayed with a hill. A real piece of work. The boy climbs. You stay near, and you don't steal it back. I went— I went home ready. Pointed at the lawn. My boy looked at the mower. Then at me. He said the lawn already has a guy. He meant me. So this lesson isn't a bigger chore. This lesson is a morning he can find later and say, that was when. If you're new in the chair, I'm Wes. Glad you sat down. Uh, some of you have a boy under your roof. Some of you have a grown son, and the calls stay short. Uh, some of you are still waiting on a sentence. Stay. If there is no son, you're not spare. A younger man in reach still has ears. You may be one of the men at his morning. A lot of us think we already marked it. We showed up. We paid for something. We stood in a picture. He still can't find the day later and say what changed. A picture proves he attended. It doesn't prove he was named. Uh, I have stood in those pictures. Smiled. Drove home. Nothing in the truck was different. I mean, love isn't a marker. You don't need a perfect speech. You need a morning that happened, and ordinary days that don't undo it. Stay with me. A day, in plain speech, is men around him. A word he can repeat. A weight in his hand. And a welcome that doesn't sound like the old voice. You can— you can love a boy for years and still leave him guessing what all that love was for. The day is the marker. The Tuesdays after it are the handoff. A stone with no story is only a rock.

You've carried one sentence through this whole room. I have not improved it. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. You've heard it in this room. Uh, I'm not rebuilding it today. In this lesson that sentence gets a morning. Stop waiting, on this one, means you don't wait for him to invent the day. The rest of the line is what you say over him when you finally stand there. Uh, you can hang that sentence on a wall and still never aim it at a boy. I have nodded at it for a long time. Nodding is cheap. A morning costs you witnesses. It costs you a line you can't tidy later. That's why a man puts it off. He'd rather stay vague and call the vagueness humble. I'm— I'm not asking you to lecture him. Uh, he has heard lectures. I want a day he will not mix up with an errand. You've been putting three names on him. Mine. What you see. Man. Those stay. They are the floor. The fourth name is the one this lesson is for. You're becoming a man. That's what this lesson is. Here's what it means. Then you say the line, slow, like you mean every word. Uh, if your mouth has been casual with those three, the fourth will feel too big. Say it anyway. If those three names have been in your house, you are closer than you feel. The fourth isn't a new religion. It's the hour you stop hinting. Uh, a boy can survive a shaky voice. He doesn't survive a missing morning. And if the Father has already called you son, you're not inventing manhood in the driveway. You are handing on a

word that started above you. God's pay isn't a room that felt moved. It's a boy who knows what he is, and a father who told him the truth.

Now listen. Put this in your ear. You'll see it in the workbook. Joshua four, verses six and seven. To serve as a sign among you. In the future, when your children ask you, What do these stones mean? Tell them that the flow of the Jordan was cut off before the ark of the covenant of the Lord. When it crossed the Jordan, the waters of the Jordan were cut off. These stones are to be a memorial to the people of Israel forever. What do these stones mean. That question is the gift. God wanted a marker his people could point at, so a son down the line would ask, and a father would have a true answer ready. Uh, not a mood he hoped the boy caught. A thing. A place. A sentence. Uh, Israel didn't trust the memory to stay warm by itself. They piled a sign, and they told the men what to say when the question came. Uh, a sign nobody can explain is just a pile. The telling is what makes it a memorial. You can leave a boy a house, a decent truck, a name he already carries, and if you never said what the men meant, he inherits objects. He doesn't inherit a story. Uh, most of our houses are thin on that for sons. I mean, we have birthdays. We have the end of a school year. We have a dinner where somebody gets thanked. We don't have a morning where the men say, plainly, you are a man, here is the meaning, and you belong with us. Uh, so he guesses. He will— he will pick a marker from whatever is lying around. I mean, he has to. A boy is going to decide when his life turned. If you don't hand him the day, he will crown one himself. And the one he crowns is usually smaller than he is. So try the question while he's still here. What do these stones mean. If you don't have an answer yet, you just found the work.

I tried to borrow a ceremony once. End of a season. Team dinner. I had remarks. My boy spent the remarks folding his napkin. Into a smaller napkin. On the way to the truck he asked what was for later. He had not stored a line. Uh, a room can be full and still have no before and no after. No word he can say back. No weight in his hand. No moment the men welcomed him in. He supplies his own if you skip it. Uh, I've watched a boy decide he crossed the day a boss used his last name. Another one folded a wad of cash like he had invented money. Another came home with a scar he was proud of, and a story that got bigger every telling. Scraps. He grabbed them because nobody put the real thing in his hand. None of those made him a man. They made him feel briefly tall. Uh, tall wears off. Then he goes hunting another scrap. Here's the thing. Uh, a party feels like you did your job. You know, people saw you. You spent some money. There was noise, so it must have mattered. It didn't— it didn't count, not if he can't tell you what changed. You know the test. A year later, ask him what that night was. If he remembers the food and not a sentence, you hosted. You didn't mark him. Ask him, when you're not performing, what he thinks the marker was. Then don't correct him. Uh, if it comes out small, believe him. He is reporting the size of the gift. I don't say that to shame a good dinner. Uh, eat with your boy. I'm for it. Just don't call the dinner a crossing when nothing in him was named. The crossing has men, a word, a weight, and a welcome. Leave one of those out and he's back to scraps.

I built my own out of scraps. The day they stopped seating me with the little kids. The day my name showed up on a bill. The day I realized nobody was coming to tell me I could stop auditioning. Uh, I called those a ceremony. They were just the calendar moving. You know, my dad was good to me in a lot of ways. Uh, he worked. He stayed. He never sat me down and said what a man is, and that I was one. I kept— I kept waiting for the sentence. Uh, the waiting got comfortable. I got older, and I got skilled at looking finished. Then I caught my boy trying on other people's approval like a coat he hoped would fit. I heard myself in it. That coat was other men's laughter. A little status. A chair he didn't have to earn at home. Uh, I recognized the fit. I had worn the same one. Let me see your hands. How many of you can point to a morning when men told you what a man is, and told you that you were in? Go on. I'm not collecting names. Look around. Uh, some of you have one. A lot of you don't. If your hand stayed down, you are in good company. You are not stuck with the scraps. Doubt that you can pass on what you never got. That doubt feels honest. It's also wrong. The giving reaches a place in you that the receiving would have reached. You don't have to feel qualified. You have to tell the truth, and stand there while he hears it. If you did get a day, don't get proud. Ask whether you've been living like it counted, or whether you framed it and walked off. You know, a framed morning can become another scrap. If you got a real one, ask whether the days after still agree.

So what does a day like that actually take. Not a program. A shape. When. You can feel the crossing, right? The voice starts to move. The shoulders change. He watches men the way he used to watch a game. That's your window. Uh, if you missed it, hold the morning anyway. Late is still a sentence. A missing one is just a hole. Uh, I have used late as a reason to stay quiet. Late was fear, wearing a practical face. Who. You, and a few men he already respects. Men who will still answer when the morning is old. Not a crowd. I mean, too many bodies and everybody starts performing. If you don't have those men yet, go get them before you pretend you have a date. You've learned, in rooms like this, how to ask a man to walk with you. Where. Outside, if you can. Early. A place that already cost him something. A field he got tired on. A road he knows in the dark. I mean, the arrival itself should ask a little. Not a rented room with a speaker in the corner. If the only spot you can picture serves food, you are planning a party. Move it. Put it where he has to arrive. Before you go, he knows— he knows a morning is coming. He doesn't get the script. You meet those men once. Each one brings a true thing. What a man is, from his own years. One failure, and what he did after. One charge, aimed at this boy. Tell them not to impress him. Uh, tell them to tell the truth. A boy can smell a speech that was built to sound like a man. Short enough that the boy can say it back. Uh, if a man can't tell the truth in that small a space, he's not ready for the morning. You'd rather have fewer men than a performance.

I sat down to write the sentence. Uh, the real one. I ended up in the junk drawer. Rubber bands in a row. The rubber bands have never been safer. The page was still blank. A tidy drawer will not raise him. Uh, so here's the morning, plain. You get there by going, and you go quiet, so the weight can sit on him before the words do. Uh, somebody reads. Short. A piece of Scripture you

have actually lived. Joshua's question is enough if you can tell the story behind it. Then the men, in turn. He stands. He receives. Uh, he will remember more than you think. You go last among the words that name him. The three names. Then the fourth. You're becoming a man. That's what this lesson is. Here's what it means. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. Say which of the four you are weakest at. Uh, he already suspects. Your honesty will do more than your polish. Say it— say it in your own hand, on a page he can keep. The handwriting can be ugly. Ugly and true beats neat and borrowed. Uh, then the token. Something that feels serious in the hand, not something that shows what you spent. If you can't say the meaning when you pass it, it's a souvenir. Uh, then you pray. Hands on him. Yours last. If your voice goes, leave it where he can see. A son learns something when his father weeps and finishes anyway. Then the plain sentence. You are one of us. Uh, then you go eat. And at that table you talk to him the way you talk to a man. He will notice. He has been waiting to hear the difference.

I'll call him Dale. His boy had reached the age where he studied men. Dale had— Dale had been kind in passing. Never a morning set aside. The boy took work at a feed store. Uh, the men there started saving him a stool. Dale heard him one night, laughing like he had finally been let in. Somebody else was doing the welcome. Dale sat on that. Then he got embarrassed enough to move. He asked a few men the boy already trusted. A neighbor who had paid him for summer work. And the man Dale met with on purpose. The ball field behind the old middle school. The boy had stood in that outfield till his legs shook. Dale said, be ready early. Didn't say for what. The boy got in the truck with a face like he was in trouble. The neighbor told about a bid he had padded, and the morning he went back and ate the cost in front of the customer. The other man said what he wished someone had put on him before he left home. Then Dale. The three names. Then the fourth. His writing was a mess. He handed the page over anyway. Then a hinge pin from a gate they had hung. Dale said a gate is only a wish until the pin is in. You are in a few lives now. Stay when it would be easier to slip out. They prayed. Dale's voice went. He finished. Then a diner, already full of working men. The neighbor didn't ask what position the boy used to play. He asked what they ought to do about a fence that kept going down. And he waited. The boy answered. They used the answer. Uh, Dale told me the ride home was a new kind of quiet. Like somebody had moved the boy's chair. Uh, next Tuesday Dale handed him a list for a side job and left the driveway. Didn't watch from the window. The boy botched the order of the stops. Called. Dale asked what he was going to do. The boy fixed it. That night Dale said, that's a man's mess, and a man's repair. The pin had a story. Before that Tuesday, it was only a piece of metal.

The morning doesn't finish him. Uh, I need you to hear that. The day— the day is a marker. It isn't a spell. Uh, I have watched a man do the brave part, say the true thing, hand over something heavy, and then go back, on an ordinary day, to managing a boy. I mean, the son files the morning under a nice speech. Uh, what makes it real is the different treatment after. You

give him work that belongs to a man. You ask what he thinks, and then you actually use it. You correct him the way you'd correct a man you respect. When he fails, the bar stays up, and so does the mercy. Skip that, and the token is a souvenir with a date on it. Uh, I know the slide. I had a real talk with my boy in the driveway. I thought we had turned something. We walked— we walked inside like the hard part was over. I asked if he had brushed his teeth. Same tone I use for a missing sock. He heard the old voice before the door shut. Uh, the morning can't live next to that voice. Tuesday has to sound like the sentence you spent. Uh, Dale knew it. The list in the boy's hand was the handoff. Not a speech on top of a speech. A man's work, a man's miss, a man's repair, and a father who didn't grab the wheel back. You already know how to mark a finish at work. A send-off. A plaque. A word in front of people. Don't spend your ceremonies on the job and leave the boy with a guess. The day is the marker. The Tuesdays are the handoff. A stone with no story is only a rock. If the story stops on the morning, you gave him a rock. Give him the day. Then give him the days that agree with it.

Now the chair you are actually in. If you— if you never got a day, you can still give one. Uh, I'll call him Frank. His son was grown. Frank thought the chance had dried up. They were in an aisle, looking at paint. The son said, are we ever going to have the talk, or is the aisle the rest of it? Frank said, not by the paint. They sat in the truck, doors open. Frank had the sentence on a page. Couldn't get it into the air. So the son read it back, slow. Frank said, yes. That's the one. I'm just late. Uh, an older man Frank had asked along looked at Frank, not the boy. He said, you did right by him. And you are a man. The hour you missed didn't close. Frank almost left that man off. He didn't think he was allowed to need it too. You can ask for that after your boy's morning. A hand, and a true word. Uh, young, and nobody has marked you. Receive one if an older man will give it. If you can't set a son's day yet, spend one true thing on a younger man. Single. You are not a guest on this. Uh, be ready with one true thing. If you know a boy whose father isn't there, ask his mother first, in the light, before you build a thing. Uh, if the marriage came apart, you can still do this. Tell his mother the aim. The boy is the subject. Keep the old argument out of the morning. If no day is a wound, go slow. I will not make that funny. Tell a brother when you are ready. Uh, a baby in the house. You are not behind. Put a date on a page, and the sentence you mean to say when his shoulders start to change. A seed is still a stone. Grown son. He still has ears. Grandson. Offer to stand with his father. Never had a son. You are not the mascot in the corner. Stand at a morning. Bring one true thing. And if you have a daughter, she needs a marked word too. Her mother in the room. Who she is, and what a man owes her. Don't give him a morning and leave her in the quiet.

Let me land it. We've covered a lot of ground in this room. Here it comes down to a morning a boy can point at. I'm not opening another map. The work in front of you is a day. The day is the marker. The Tuesdays are the handoff. A stone with no story is only a rock. Uh, what I hope you walk out with isn't a warmer opinion about fathering. It's a date. And the names of men who will show up. Uh, you will know whether you got a day. You will know what you used if you didn't.

You will know if your boy is guessing. And you will not leave having only agreed with an idea. Your workbook is where this gets particular. Uh, in a minute you'll sit at the tables and work this part together. Get the questions in your ear. Did you get a day, and if you didn't, what did you use instead? Does your son have one coming, or has he been guessing? Date, men, place, token. What goes on the calendar? Write the three names, and the fourth. A son in the house, or a younger man in reach. Both of you own the page. Uh, tell a brother. Ask him— ask him to be one of the men. Tell him what to prepare. One story. One failure. One charge. If he has a son, ask when that day is, and offer to stand. If there is no son, ask to stand at a morning, or ask a mother about a boy whose father isn't there. Do it in the light. Carry this, and write it where you'll see it.

The day is the marker. The Tuesdays are the handoff. A stone with no story is only a rock. Give him the day. Then live the days that make it true. Before you go to those tables, give me a few more minutes. This is the last lesson we do together. I want to say it plain. Think back to the first lesson. Folding chairs. A bunch of guys just checking it out. I told you about a bike tire I fixed in the dark, by myself. I did the job and missed the girl. And I told you a man's life gets decided on the days nobody photographs. Look at what you did since then. You kept showing up on ordinary days. You sat at a table and told the truth to men who could check on you. Some of you texted a brother, and he texted back. Some of you missed a move, and came back anyway. I mean, that last one counts the most. So let me put the four in front of you one more time, my own way. Don't wait on the feeling. Carry what's yours. Step out ahead of your people. And do it for the Father's reward, the inheritance he gives his kids, not the clapping. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. That line isn't the end of anything. It's how you walk out of here.

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